I persuaded the Indian embassy in Paris to allot a locker to store the documents that came from Vernon every day. Only my office assistant Unni, draughtsman Muthusamy and I knew about the diplomatic channel.

What went in those bags were, again, know-how. For the know-why, we put a team back home to design a prototype based on the documents and drawings. These included details of every system, subsystem and sub-subsystem; applied mechanics that went into their making; and details of materials to be used. This is a basic practice in engineering to develop something based on a design, without directly copying from the original, and see at the end of it how much the prototype is close to the original.

Every spacefaring nation has taken either of the two paths: borrowing basics from another country and developing on them or starting from scratch and developing its own rockets. Both involves trial and error for decades; the latter route takes longer than the former. Germany was clearly a pioneer, with geniuses like von Braun developing the V2 rocket that Hitler had used to fire across the English Channel. The US mostly developed its own systems. China got its basics from the Russians, who are clearly the leaders even today when it comes to efficiency, though today's Russia is a pale shadow of the erstwhile USSR.

India, though helped generously by the Russians, was developing its first liquid propulsion engine with the help from France. India can take pride in having developed an indigenous cryogenic engine, but we owe a lot to the Russians who parted with seven engines. But again, we could not work with the Russians as we did it with the French. They might have agreed for the Viking-Vikas contract purely for business reasons, and we designed a contract that with a barter system of 'technology for man hours' to hook them, but we owe a lot to the French. *Merci beaucoup*!

In three years, the Viking-Vikas engine was almost ready. And we were confident of reproducing a Viking (Vikas for us) back home. However, as per the contract, ISRO had to provide seventy-five man years to SEP, and our men came and left in batches up to 1980, some of them working on other projects at SEP.